

Pahankanuwa Sermon #20

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

*Pheṇūpamaṃ kāyamimaṃ veditvā, marīcidhammaṃ
abhisambudhāno; Chetvāna mārassa papupphakāni, adassanaṃ
maccurājassa gacche.*

From:

Verse 46 from the Pupphavagga (Chapter on Flowers) of the
Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

The great deathless Nibbāna is the highest aspiration and ultimate goal of every Buddhist. Why is this word 'deathless' (*amṛta*) so dear to everyone when it falls upon their ears? It is because they see and feel a solution in this word 'deathless' to the grave problem of death, which everyone born in this world must face. Not only for humans, but even for devas and brahmas, 'deathless' is a beloved word. That is because, even if they live for aeons, they must someday pass away and die. Therefore, this word 'deathless' is extremely pleasing and agreeable.

Why, then, do we pay such great homage to our Supreme Buddha, the Father? It is because the Buddha stepped forward to address this very problem of death, which the world, including devas and humans, was looking at in despair. That is what is called the great, deathless Nibbāna.

We know that the Buddha defeated Māra. What is the meaning of defeating Māra? The Buddha discovered a place invisible to Māra, a place beyond the grasp of Māra. That is what is called the Nibbāna-dhātu* (the element of Nibbāna, the great deathless Nibbāna). It is described by terms such as the *Asaṅkhata-dhātu* (the Unconditioned / Unprepared / Uncompounded element). It is by directing

the mind to a certain state that is invisible to Māra, which Māra cannot see, that one conquers death. The Buddha did not merely realize that deathless state, that great deathless Nibbāna, for himself; he has also presented in this Dhamma the relevant, helpful instructions for the world to reach that state, to defeat Māra within their own mental continuums, and to realize that deathless state. In the verse we have chosen as our topic today, what is shown very briefly is an instruction on insight (*vipassanā*) that helps direct the mind to this deathless state.

This Dhamma verse was preached to a certain monk who, having taken a meditation subject (*kammaṭṭhāna*) from the Buddha, went to a distant forest to practice insight meditation. Although that Venerable Sir went to such a forest with a meditation subject obtained from the Buddha and meditated with great effort, he was unable to attain Arahantship. Later, he thought, "I must meet the Buddha again to purify my meditation subject and receive special instructions." While traveling a long distance with this intention, he saw a mirage. During the summer, especially in dry seasons like this, a mirage is something one can easily see.

That sight of vapor rising from the ground, appearing like flowing water. Seeing this, the monk reflected, "My individual existence and this body are also like a mirage." A mirage appears from afar as if it is something real, something that can be grasped. However, when you go close to it, its nature is such that it is not there. In the same way, just as the Buddha declared, it appeared to this monk that this body is a mirage. What actually exists is not the way this body appears; it is the nature of arising and passing away. When you go closer to see where it arises, it vanishes from there. While walking and reflecting on the mirage in this manner, he reached the bank of the Aciravatī River. To soothe his bodily fatigue and rest, he bathed, and then sat serenely under a tree where the river water flowed very rapidly, watching how foam-bubbles formed and dissolved in the swift current of the river. This too became a meditation subject for that monk. He reflected, "This form of mine, this body, this physical frame, this individual existence, is also like a lump of foam." While he was reflecting on this, the Buddha—who usually watches with his Buddha-knowledge the mental behavior and the way the minds of the monks to whom he gave meditation subjects are working—saw that this monk's mind had now matured.

At that moment, the Buddha appeared—having seen the thought that arose in this monk, the Buddha appeared before him and spoke the Dhamma verse we mentioned earlier:

"Knowing this body to be comparable to a lump of foam, understanding through wisdom its mirage-like nature, cutting off the flower-tipped arrows of Māra, one should go to a place beyond the sight of the King of Death."

Confirming the thought of insight (*vipassanā*) that arose in that monk, giving him the assurance that it is true, and further encouraging him, the Buddha declared:

Phenūpamaṃ kāyaṃ imaṃ — Knowing this body to be comparable to a lump of foam,

Marīcidhammaṃ abhisambudhāno — Understanding through wisdom the mirage-like nature of this body, comprehending it thoroughly,

Chetvāna mārassa papupphakāṇi — Cutting off the flower-tipped arrows, or the flower-decorated arrows, shot by Māra of defilements (*kilesa-māra*),

Adassanaṃ [maccurājassa gacche] — Go to a place beyond the range of Māra's sight.

In this way, the Buddha gave the instruction. It is recorded that upon hearing this instruction, that Venerable Sir's insight knowledge matured, and he attained Arahantship with the four analytical knowledges (*paṭisambhidā*).

Let us, therefore, try to understand the Dhamma points contained in this verse with reference to this context. Comparing this body to a lump of foam—the Buddha has compared form (*rūpa*) to a lump of foam. Let us contemplate for a moment how reasonable—how well-reasoned—this is. The Buddha compared form to a lump of foam because the more one thinks about it, the deeper one contemplates it, the closer one gets to the truth. Now, a lump of foam is something that arises when something, like a log of wood or some debris, gets stuck in a rapidly flowing stream of water, and as they are carried away by the water, foam rises from them.

From afar, that foam appears solid, as if it is something substantial, something *nicca* (permanent/constant), something of essence. But when one looks closely, it is devoid of essence; it is empty. Moreover, this lump of foam has a nature that exists for only a very brief moment. If we look at a lump of foam in an extremely subtle manner, it is like a collection of bubbles rapidly arising and passing away. This body is also like that. Yet, when we look at it as form (*rūpa*), what we see is like what we said about that foam. What is its mirage-like nature? From afar, it appears as an extremely pleasant, permanent (*nicca*) thing. But this body is built up just like that lump of foam. We know that all kinds of food and drink enter this body.

Milk, gruel, rice—these are boiled and frothed up in the kitchen before they enter this body. After entering the body, they boil and froth up even further. It is through the boiling and overflowing of this foam that blood, flesh, bones, and sinews are formed. Once these are formed and the foam overflows, we become deeply attached to the portion of the body we wish to keep, thinking "this is mine, this is I," and with great pride, we decorate, adorn, feed, and pamper this body, maintaining it. The leftover part of that foam, the part that overflows to the outside as feces, urine, sweat, etc., we wash away as waste. When we contemplate, this is the nature of the lump of foam regarding this body.

As the Buddha declared, these thirty-two impure parts of the body are brought together in this very manner. Due to the boiling nature within this body, based on the primary elements of **paṭhavī** (earth), **āpo** (water), **tejo** (fire), and **vāyo** (air), this body continues to grow for many years, constantly frothing. It is a lump of foam. Therefore, fully understanding the nature of this body as a lump of foam—**phenūpamaṃ kāyaṃ imaṃ**.

Similarly, its mirage-like nature means that from afar, if we do not look with the eye of wisdom, it appears as something good and pleasant. Now, whether we take a photograph or look in a mirror, when we look with the ordinary physical eye—what we call the natural eye, our normal eye—it appears to us as a very pleasant form (**rūpa**), both our own form and the forms of others. In the world, there are instruments to see things invisible to the physical eye, such as microscopes. What do they do? They magnify subtle things. Magnifying subtle things is a form of distortion. Yet, we are satisfied with it, thinking, "Look, I am seeing a subtle thing." However, wisdom (**paññā**) or insight (**vipassanā**) does not see in that way. It sees the subtle thing exactly as a subtle thing. That is a direct realization. It is confirmed by directly realizing the subtle thing as a subtle thing. Otherwise, we only see it as long as the instrument is there. Once the instrument is removed, it is gone. There is such a difference in the world regarding seeing, and insight (**vipassanā**) is a special kind of seeing—the seeing of the practitioner of insight.

To understand that form is a lump of foam in this manner, there is no need to labor to place parts of it under a microscope. There is no need to spend money. By constantly contemplating any part of this form, such as hair of the head, hair of the body, nails, teeth, etc., from among the thirty-two impure parts of the body—whichever part strikes one as most repulsive—as a meditation subject in the manner of tranquility (**samatha**), by anchoring the mind therein through one-pointedness, and by seeing it deeply, then it is understood. Consequently, an opportunity arises to see its elemental nature (**dhātu**) in the manner of insight (**vipassanā**). As insight knowledge matures, one can remove the attachment to this body by viewing it as repulsive (**asubha**) or as elements (**dhātu**), and

comprehend its true nature. There is a word, *nibbedhikā paññā*. Meritorious friends, *nibbedhikā paññā* means penetrative wisdom. Wisdom is something that penetrates.

Now, when we think of this body, we often use the term 'bodily cage'. Indeed, it is a cage. Inside this bodily cage, the mind is trapped. This cage is a cage made by Māra, a cage created by Māra. Inside this bodily cage created by Māra, the mind is imprisoned. It is to attain the liberation of the mind, to realize Nibbāna, that a person strives, that a wise person strives. What is this realization of Nibbāna? It is the penetrating vision of this cage. It is through penetrating this cage that the mind is liberated. That penetrative seeing is precisely what is accomplished by insight (*vipassanā*).

This wisdom is so powerful that it has been compared to a diamond gem (*vajra-māṇikya*). Now, a diamond is something that can cut other gems. A diamond has the strength and sharpness to cut through any other gem. This insight knowledge (*vipassanā-ñāṇa*) is like a diamond; it penetrates. It sees through. Seeing through means—now, when we say seeing *aniccatā* (impermanence/inconstancy), there are two sides, two aspects to impermanence: arising and passing away. It begins with contemplating the nature of its arising and passing away. As one goes deeper, through that one penetrates and sees that there is nothing real here. The nature of *Anicca* (Impermanent), *Dukkha* (Suffering), *Anattā* (Not-self), and emptiness of essence can be seen through this as one goes deeper and deeper. Thus, seeing this arising and passing away is the initial function of this diamond gem—insight wisdom. By seeing in this way, one is able to understand this body as a lump of foam, not through any artificial instruments or artificial means. However, we attain this state through the path of insight (*vipassanā*).

In the past, during the time of the Buddha, it was these similes shown by the Buddha that the monks took with them to the forest when they went to meditate. They did not carry other books with them. They did not shoulder other volumes. Those very similes were sufficient. This is because a simile contains a vast multitude of deep meanings. However, it is grasped and understood only as one goes deeper and deeper. Simply mentioning a 'lump of foam' is something one can see anywhere, or even looking at a tree. If one just glances at it and looks away, it goes no further. But it is not just the simile, but the object of comparison (*upameya*). According to that simile, what has the Buddha compared it to? This body. At first glance, this seems hard to accept. Yet, one must direct the mind deeply into this, apply contemplation, and reflect on it. When one constantly directs the mind to this, one realizes how true indeed are the words spoken by the Buddha.

In this way, then, one who aspires for the knowledge of insight (*vipassanā-ñāṇa*) and wishes to go to that deathless state, to the place invisible to Māra, must sharpen those insight knowledges. "*Phenūpamaṃ kāyaṃ imaṃ veditvā*". Moreover, if we contemplate the mirage-like nature in this, we spoke earlier about the characteristic of a mirage. The deer is deceived by it. The deer, being largely an ignorant animal, runs towards it because from afar during the summer it appears like water. When it goes there, it is not there. Yet, based on the view (*diṭṭhi*) it has taken, it appears even further away. Thus, it keeps running continuously, and does not realize until it collapses from exhaustion. It is exactly the same regarding this form (*rūpa*). The world's attachment to this form is the work of Māra—the work of Māra of defilements (*kilesa-māra*). It is always presented as something beautiful (*subha*). That is why the Buddha pointed out that the world is trapped within four distorted views, known as *vipallāsa* (perversions/distortions). They regard the *Anicca* (Impermanent) as permanent; they regard the *asubha* (foul/repulsive) as beautiful; they regard what is bound up with *Dukkha* (Suffering) as pleasant; and they regard what is *Anattā* (Not-self) as one's self. There are such perverted views, *vipallāsa*, in the world. Accordingly, that lump of foam also appears as something permanent, extremely beautiful, something to be acquired, and full of essence. A mirage is just like that.

Thinking thus, the thirsty deer, driven by the desire to drink water, goes far. Because of the very thirst which is *Taṇhā* (Craving), that animal often takes the distant sight as a view (*diṭṭhi*), believing "this is definitely water and nothing else." Due to that view (*diṭṭhi*) it has grasped, and the subsequent thoughts built upon it, that deer runs.

In this way, the Buddha has declared that these distorted ideas, the *vipallāsa*, operate on three levels: *saññā-vipallāsa* (distortion of perception), *citta-vipallāsa* (distortion of thought), and *diṭṭhi-vipallāsa* (distortion of view). *Saññā-vipallāsa* refers to perception/recognition. The deer perceives the distant mirage as water. Then, based on that perception, it constructs a multitude of thoughts: "If I go there, I will be able to drink some water." Because of those thoughts, expectations, and wishes, the deer runs. Based on what is seen far away, it forms a view (*diṭṭhi*): "This is definitely water; even if it is not here, it is visible over there. Because it is visible, it can definitely be obtained." Indeed, this is the nature of the mirage regarding this body, and it is the same with other things that support the body.

In our day-to-day life, we know how these three factors operate. Sometimes, one's neighbor brings a brand new luxury item to their house. Seeing this, one thinks, "Somehow, I must acquire this too." This is indeed the mirage. One thinks, "On

the day I acquire this, I too will be someone of status." Thinking thus, one goes into debt for it. Getting into debt, working hard, one somehow acquires that item—the item that was in the neighbor's living room. But by the time one acquires it, the neighbor's item has been moved to the kitchen, and a new item has arrived. Then, one tries to acquire that new one. This is the track on which the world runs. Just like regarding this body, the world spends its entire life with such a *Taṇhā* (Craving), a severe craving, for luxury items that support the body. Such is the situation. This happens because of Māra. That is the part mentioned next in the verse.

"*Chetvāna mārassa papupphakāṇi*" — Cutting off Māra's flower-arrows, or the arrows with flower-tips. A deep meaning is expressed here. What are these arrows? Māra of defilements shoots these arrows at our six senses. What is shown here are the objects coming to the eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind—the defiled sense objects. Since these defiled sense objects come with a pleasant appearance, they are shown as flower-arrows. If one cannot cut off these flower-arrows properly—one looks at the arrow because there is a flower at its tip. But even though one looks at the flower, it comes and pierces the eye. That is the kind of thing happening here. So, what is used to help cut down this nature of defilements? It is that same diamond gem (*vajra-māṇikya*) we mentioned earlier—insight wisdom (*vipassanā-paññā*). This is called 'insight attention' (*vipassanā-manasikāra*), a form of contemplation. It is through insight attention that one can cut off these defiled sense objects.

Generally, through contemplation, if one contemplates like the ordinary world—that is, foolishly—or if one contemplates while being overwhelmed by defilements, what happens is that one takes up various signs (*nimitta*) based on that object. An object does not come alone; it comes with signs. Defilements give various signs to the mind: "This is beautiful (*subha*), this is permanent (*nicca*), this is pleasant (*sukha*), it brings pleasure, it is a good thing, this is mine"—it gives such feelings. Moreover, it has an attractive appearance. Accordingly, there is a nature in these sense objects that increases desire. It is through insight wisdom (*vipassanā-paññā*) that one can cut off this stickiness, this state of attachment, this state of bondage to the object, and see through the objects. That is how one cuts off these defiling arrows, these defiling objects shot by Māra. In that way, one contemplates the object extremely rapidly, not to succumb to those signs, but to use these objects to see the three characteristics—*Anicca* (Impermanent), *Dukkha* (Suffering), and *Anattā* (Not-self)—declared by the Buddha. "There, it came; here, it remained; lo, it has gone." The object came, remained, and went. What is understood through this? How true indeed is the nature of *anicca* declared by the Buddha! Next, through that very

contemplation, one sees that if one develops attachment to it, along with that comes the grief, fear, and torment born of separation from it.

Now, within those insight knowledges (*vipassanā-ñāṇa*) declared by the Buddha lies the entire sum of experiences we have gathered over an infinite time in this *saṃsāra*. It is by applying this vast store of experiences in an extremely brief moment and turning it into a state that cuts through like a diamond that one can be liberated from this *saṃsāra*, liberated from *Bhava* (Becoming). What is the solution given by the Buddha? It is not the solution the ordinary world thinks of. The ordinary world sees in everything *Taṇhā* (Craving) and holding on, which is called *taṇhā-upādāna* (craving and grasping/holding). They grasp with craving. It is through this grasping (*upādāna*) that the ordinary world expects security. We know that when a small child feels fear, they cling to their mother. The mother might cling to her husband. If a thief comes, or if someone comes to kill them, they might cling to security guards. You, meritorious friends, know very well these days that none of these clings or holdings are permanent. One can never conquer Māra or death through this nature of grasping and holding.

Instead, the Buddha gives a highly marvelous solution, one that is unimaginable to an ordinary person. The Buddha declares: "When Māra pulls, let go!" One must let go of Māra. Why? Because within the momentum of Māra's pull, there is a mental state that brings grief, fear, torment, and lamentation. If someone firmly grasps or holds onto something, when that grasped object is pulled, it gives rise to fear, torment, and grief. Let us suppose someone clings to a thorny branch. When that thorny branch is pulled, this person's hand is also wounded. Similarly, regarding the *upādāna* (grasping/holding/fuel) in this world, the Buddha declared: "I do not see any single thing in this *Bhava* (Becoming) which, when grasped, can bring safety." It is difficult for someone to comprehend this. At various levels, a person decides: "I will grasp only this much." But the Buddha declares that as long as one grasps, through every single thing one becomes prey to Māra.

To what extent, meritorious friends? The Buddha has declared—and as Buddhists we have often heard—that what we call 'I' and 'mine' are just five heaps: *rūpa* (form), *Vedanā* (Feeling), *saññā* (perception), *Saṅkhāra* (Formations), and *viññāṇa* (consciousness). The Buddha has identified every single one of these heaps as Māra. Form is Māra, feeling is Māra, perception is Māra, formations are Māra, and consciousness is Māra. Since all of these belong to Māra, what is it that does not belong to Māra? Right there lies the bliss of liberation. This is not something obtained by grasping (*upādāna*).

Let us take a simple analogy for this. Let us contemplate a game of tug-of-war. What happens in a tug-of-war? At the beginning, we know that the two teams on either side grab the rope with all their might. If needed, they even wrap it around their hands. With a firm determination not to let it budge even a bit, they cling to the rope. Then, suppose one side, which we think can win, pulls it. As they pull, if the others keep clinging to it, some fall to the ground, get scraped, and suffer injuries. This is a very obvious fact to us. But regarding that victory, there too is a mirage. Because of the mirage, they grasp it firmly. They think they have won. Amidst great panting, they express joy. Such is the situation according to the world. What the Buddha points out is not that kind of thing. It is letting go of Māra. If one lets go when Māra pulls with all his momentum, what happens? Then the strain is on Māra. The strain is on Māra. Oneself is free. For oneself, there is no fear, grief, torment, or lamentation. Letting go. This is something one can realize in day-to-day life.

Let us suppose we are very proud of our set of teeth. A front tooth begins to ache. A toothache arises. We somehow bear the toothache. "If this tooth is lost, it will be a major flaw on our face." But the dentist says, "This is a decayed tooth. If it is not removed somehow, it will harm the other teeth as well." Then, on that day, putting aside the attachment to that tooth, one allows it to be extracted. Once it is extracted, there is relief. That is the matter concerning the tooth that must be understood. Such is the situation in the world. Although this is mentioned as a simple illustration from daily life, it is not understood immediately. However, those who walked on the path of Dhamma shown by the Buddha have realized this. They let go of things that seemed impossible to let go. Why? Because they saw that each of these is like a subtle arrow of Māra—each is an invitation from Māra. He gives it to be grasped: "Here, grasp this!" And then he pulls. The moment it is grasped, he pulls.

Through this grasping, let us try to reveal a deeper Dhamma using this very simile. Now, we spoke about grasping the rope. In a tug-of-war, when grasping the rope, how much effort, exertion, energy, or resistance (*orottu-vīma*) is applied? What an endeavor is made to grasp and hug this rope! In the same way, regarding everything in this world, there is a nature of clinging through mind, speech, and body in the form of intentions, aspirations, and expectations. Or, to put it another way, there are many "preparations" (*ara-ændīm*). You, meritorious friends, know the word *ara-ændīma* (preparations/arrangements). It is a preparation, a grand preparation, when we contemplate our entire life. Life in its entirety is a preparation, an endeavor, to live, to stay alive, to avoid dying. A series of preparations (*saṅkhāra* / formations / volitional activities). Even before these preparations are completed, before these arrangements are fully finished, Māra pulls it away. At that moment, as we mentioned earlier, one falls

into fear, torment, and lamentation. One thinks, "I have died." Thinking so, owing to the defilements, due to Māra of defilements, one somehow takes another *Jāti* (Birth) in another place according to kamma. Then, one settles down there. One takes root there. Māra pulls towards the next world, while the dying person pulls towards this world. In the end, the Buddha declared this to be a pulling that leaves one with neither world. Once this pulling is over, one goes and settles there, taking root.

Suppose one has a human form and then goes and is born in the womb of an animal. Next, due to *avijjā* (ignorance), one clings to that bodily cage. One clings to what pertains to that body, thinking, "this is I, this is mine." This is how it is. This is what is called the journey of *saṃsāra*. This journey is not one that can be measured in miles or meters. That journey of *saṃsāra* exists between these two: 'this world' and 'the next world,' the place one grasps in this manner. Or, as we say, between 'there' and 'here.' Now, in the case of the mirage, the deer is here and sees the water over there, and what does it use to connect 'there' and 'here'? Conceit (*māna*). If we say *Taṇhā* (Craving) is the thought the deer develops from here—it develops the thought based on craving. It supports the sight seen over there. It connects the two through conceit (*māna*): "If I go there, I can drink that water."

In this way, according to the three defilements of *Taṇhā* (Craving), *māna* (conceit), and *diṭṭhi* (views), worldly beings travel this long journey of *saṃsāra*. Although we call it a long journey, it is like spinning in one place. It is highly astonishing how it is just a spinning in the selfsame place. If it is such a cycle, one cannot escape by running. It is because of this that the liberated Buddha declared: "Within this fathom-long body, I declare the arising of the world, the cessation of the world, and the path leading to it." To do this, as we mentioned earlier, one must see through this bodily cage. One must see through every single one of these. The Buddha has shown only two similes here. In the Dhamma, similes are shown for all the five aggregates (*pañcupādānakkhandha*). You, meritorious friends, must have heard many times that form (*rūpa*) is compared to a lump of foam, feeling (*vedanā*) to water bubbles—like bubbles that rapidly arise and burst when rain falls on water.

Next, *saññā* (perception) was said to be a mirage. *Saṅkhāra* (Formations)—we understood *saṅkhāra* as all those various intentions, aspirations, expectations, preparations, and arrangements. We do this through mind, body, and speech. Even in the tug-of-war we mentioned, those words are used—body, speech, and mind. A massive effort—a multitude of efforts—is made through all these in a tug-of-war. A series of preparations and arrangements, just like this heap of *saṅkhāra*. There is no essence in these; they are devoid of essence.

Formations (*saṅkhāra*) are compared to a banana trunk. One goes in search of the heartwood of a banana trunk. Because of the initial appearance of the banana tree, a person seeing it for the first time might think, "This is a wood with good heartwood." But when one starts peeling it, touching it very closely, lo! it is just a sheath. What appeared so good was just a sheath, not heartwood. One discards it. "Now, here is the heartwood," one thinks. That too is just a sheath. One discards it too. "Ah, that too is just a sheath." Finally, one reaches the core. Even there, there is nothing. Even there, there is no essence. Within it, there are only many sheaths.

In this way, throughout the entirety of *saṃsāra*, meritorious friends, what we have been doing is merely peeling sheaths. We have found no heartwood. Searching for heartwood, we have gone on peeling sheaths. That is why the Buddha declared: "*Saṅkhārā paramā dukkhā*" (formations are the ultimate suffering). The subtlest *Dukkha* (Suffering) in the world is the suffering of formations (*saṅkhāra-dukkha*). Generally, what we call suffering is when we lose a loved one, fall sick, get ill, or have nothing to eat or drink—these are what we call suffering. But the Buddha declared that the subtlest level of suffering is formations (*saṅkhāra*). This is understood only by the practitioner of insight (*vipassanā*). Gradually, the suffering in this is understood. To cure a disease, what does a doctor do? First, they alleviate the externally visible symptoms, like a fever or pain. But the disease is not cured thereby. One must treat the root cause itself. Similarly, the Buddha discovered the very source of this disease and removed that cause. That source is *Taṇhā* (Craving). The Buddha pointed out craving. It is because of craving that we grasp (*upādāna*). Why do all these five heaps become suffering? Because we grasp them, because we hold onto them. As long as we hold onto them, they are suffering. Once let go, there is no suffering. But the way of the world is to grasp each of these, saying, "this is I, this is mine." Grasping means the unwillingness to let go. Holding on means the unwillingness to let go.

To reveal this, the ordinary world takes up views (*diṭṭhi*) regarding each of these. Regarding form, they say: "Form is mine." If someone asks what the relationship is between form and you, they say, "This form is mine." If you logically show them that it cannot be so, they say, "No, no, I made a small mistake; I am one who possesses form." Or, "Form is in me." Or, "I am in form." In this manner. What does this show? They are unwilling to let go of form. They cling to it somehow in those four ways. Clinging in this manner in twenty ways is what is called *Sakkāya-diṭṭhi* (View of existing group/body). That is what is called view (*diṭṭhi*).

This unwillingness to let go is something caused by *Taṇhā* (Craving). Due to craving comes *upādāna* (grasping/holding/fuel). Once grasped, that tug-of-war is what takes place. Why, then, are formations (*saṅkhāra*) compared to a banana trunk in this manner? If someone thinks, "The Buddha compared formations to a banana tree. We have plenty of banana trees in our garden. Therefore, it is very easy for me to understand formations," they are mistaken. One must consider this deeply. That is how formations are. Consciousness (*viññāṇa*) is something far subtler. Consciousness is compared to an illusion (*māyā*). An illusion, in modern terms, is a magic trick. People go to watch magic shows with great interest. Why do they go? To be deceived. Not for free, but by paying money to be deceived! But this deception has always been going on in *saṃsāra*, even without paying money. This deception is what is called consciousness (*viññāṇa*). Because the nature of consciousness is to show something non-existent as existing. The Buddha illustrated this with a simile of a magician performing a trick at a four-way crossroads, creating illusions. He shows non-existent things as existing. Those who are deluded see it and rejoice, saying, "Ah! Oh! Wow!" But there is nothing real there. It is devoid of essence.

This understanding that there is no essence, no heartwood, is what the Buddha ultimately presents to a person as Nibbāna. The ordinary world thinks of Nibbāna as some kind of strange world. That is the place invisible to Māra. What is called the place invisible to Māra is that state of mind. That is to say, if someone has attained that supramundane state declared by the Buddha through Arahantship in this very life, at the moment of their death, when Māra pulls, they do not pull back towards this side. Instead, if Māra pulls, they let go, as if saying, "If this is yours, take it." When they let go, there is no grief, torment, or lamentation. That is where the secret lies. What a wonderful solution the Buddha declared: letting go when pulled.

This letting go must first be realized in this very world. The path to that realization is called the insight knowledges (*vipassanā-ñāṇa*). It is seen through that *aniccatā* (impermanence/inconstancy). There is great depth in the word *aniccatā*. When we say *aniccatā*, we think it exists for a little while—not a year, but a month; not a month, but a day. Ultimately, when one looks at it in this way, one has to see through this as well. How does it come to realization through both arising and passing away? To one who is watching both, they see these breaking down faster than they arise. Now, why did that Venerable Sir, upon seeing that lump of foam, compare it to this body? It appeared to him that this body breaks down even faster than it arises. To that extent, this is something that constantly breaks down. This breaking-down nature is not visible to the ordinary physical eye. As we mentioned earlier, even if one sees it through microscopes,

that is not direct knowledge (*paccakkha-ñāṇa*). Even if seen in a laboratory, one forgets it upon returning home. Therefore, for it to be realized, it must be a direct realization. It is visible only to a mind prepared with *samādhi* (concentration), *upekkhā* (equanimity), and *ekaggatā* (one-pointedness). This is also what is meant by cutting off Māra's flower-arrows. Within that contemplation, these two are present: equanimity (*upekkhā*) and one-pointedness (*ekaggatā*). One-pointedness is obtained through *samādhi*. Through that, the mind becomes strong and sharp. Even with a knife, one cannot cut with a blunt knife. It must be sharpened well. Having sharpened it, next is equanimity. Equanimity has a way of aiming it correctly, keeping it steady and undistracted there. It is through these two that insight wisdom (*vipassanā-paññā*) is brought forth.

Through that wisdom, systematically, first those two: arising and passing away. Next, through that, one sees it breaking down, rapidly breaking down. As it breaks down continuously, one understands: "Why should I grasp this thing which is breaking down?" If we grasp something that is breaking down—say, a rotten fence—after grasping it, we fall along with the fence. Similarly, grasping something that is shaking or trembling brings suffering. In the same way, the Buddha declared that in each of these—*rūpa*, *vedanā*, *saññā*, *saṅkhāra*, *viññāṇa*—there is a multitude of vibrations. Formations (*saṅkhāra*) can be regarded as vibrations. It is precisely due to that multitude of grasped preparations, arrangements, expectations, intentions, and aspirations that those vibrations arise. Liberation is freedom from that mental conflict. This is why we say Nibbāna is right close to us. This is something that must be directly realized, through comprehension and wisdom. This is not just any wisdom; it is systematically and directly realized through a certain meditation subject (*kammaṭṭhāna*). Suppose, to develop disenchantment towards this body, one constantly directs one's meditation attention (*manasikāra*) to some part like hair of the head, hair of the body, nails, teeth, etc., and thereby attains a level of concentration (*samādhi*). By that, those distorted ideas called *vipallāsa* we mentioned earlier are removed. The perception of beauty (*subha-saññā*) is removed, and attachment to it ceases. Instead, one begins to understand its true nature. In that way, one contemplates it as repulsive (*asubha*).

Or else, as elements (*dhātu*)—all these things contained in this bodily cage, as well as things around us—we see certain characteristics of *paṭhavī* (earth), *āpo* (water), *tejo* (fire), and *vāyo* (air) in this great earth, in water, in fire, and in air. This too is only a grasping. We identify these just as a blind person feels around and learns. We know this is the *paṭhavī-dhātu* (earth element) because of its hardness. This too is felt by the body. It is through the body that we

understand, "this is a hard thing." Is this a flowing thing? Is this a hot, warm thing? Is this a moving, expanding thing? These four elements exist within our body. If we consider parts where the earth element is predominant, they are hair of the head, hair of the body, nails, teeth, etc. These are things through which the sensation of hardness can be brought out; when we touch them, there is hardness, stiffness, softness, and so on. Similarly, the flowing nature, the liquid nature—in saliva, phlegm, mucus, urine, etc., we feel the water element (*āpo-dhātu*) within this body. Next, through hunger, fevers, etc., we know the fire element (*tejo-dhātu*). Likewise, the wind element (*vāyo-dhātu*) through this in-breathing and out-breathing. Thus, it is through these that the Buddha showed the way to bring forth Nibbāna. There is no need to go anywhere else. It is within this very body.

Along with the body, the trees around us also preach the Dhamma. Although they do not speak in this decorated manner, these trees, leaves, flowers, and fruits—all of them preach the Dhamma. But people do not listen to them. In the Buddha's time, however, they listened to them. That is how, in the past, when the monks went to a forest, they read the books available in their solitude. The book of Dhamma is found in the trees. The Dhamma is found in the rivers. Those are the very things shown here. That monk read a book of Dhamma flowing in that river. That is the true nature of this world declared by the Buddha. The three characteristics of *Anicca* (Impermanent), *Dukkha* (Suffering), and *Anattā* (Not-self) are seen everywhere. Bringing these out from within them belongs to insight wisdom (*vipassanā-paññā*). For that, one must walk on the path declared by the Buddha.

When we contemplate this, all of these are formations (*saṅkhāra*). It is by removing the attachment to this bodily cage, by seeing through it, that one can realize that noble, supreme state of Nibbāna, that liberation, which is described as the place invisible to Māra. If one makes the mind liberated in this very world, that person is said to be stilled. That is extinguishment. Until then, there is a burning. Realizing that extinguishment is the ultimate purpose of this Dhamma. Therefore, you, meritorious friends, must also reflect in your daily life, without postponing these matters, that they exist right inside this bodily cage, this cage we constantly carry around. Let alone other things, if we contemplate for a moment on this *ānāpānasati* (mindfulness of breathing) meditation which helped every Buddha to attain Buddhahood, what is present there is the activity of the wind element (*vāyo-dhātu*). If we reflect a little on this phenomenon of in-breathing and out-breathing, we can understand this. These in-breaths and out-breaths are like the panting (*hatiya*) that arises from running this futile, long journey of *saṃsāra*. Truly, meritorious friends, *ānāpānasati* does not mean panting; do not misunderstand. *Sati* means mindfulness. But the in-

breath and out-breath, called *ānāpāna*, is indeed like a representation of the momentum, the panting, that has arisen within this running of *saṃsāra*. Contained within this is the message of this suffering of *saṃsāra*. That is why it is said that one attains Buddhahood through *ānāpānasati*.

Within this in-breathing and out-breathing, there is also *kāyānupassanā* (contemplation of the body), which is the foundation of mindfulness in observing the body. The capacity to comprehend feeling, which is *vedanānupassanā* (contemplation of feeling/sensation), is also present within this very in-breathing and out-breathing. The secret to understanding the mind, the mental behavior, and the way the mind conducts itself is also contained within this *ānāpāna*—within the in-breath and out-breath. Next, the capacity to comprehend the true nature of the objects that come to the mind, which is *dhammānupassanā* (contemplation of phenomena/mind-objects), is also present. Accordingly, when we contemplate, these in-breaths and out-breaths are like the 'panting' of this saṃsāric momentum. Quieting this—stopping the running and sitting in one place, directing the mind to this in-breath and out-breath, meritorious friends, is the settling of this 'panting' that we have brought along through our saṃsāric momentum. This panting is settled by making this in-breath and out-breath subtle. Not by forcing it, but by sitting serenely and directing the mind to it.

This breathing becomes agitated due to thoughts (*vitakka*) and ideas. The mind runs. The mind keeps running toward those defiled objects it had grasped earlier. To someone who has just sat down for *ānāpānasati* meditation, these networks of thoughts stream in so much that they might feel discouraged. But systematically, by developing the four protective meditations (*caturārakkhā*)—namely, recollection of the Buddha (*buddhānussati*), loving-kindness (*mettā*), repulsiveness (*asubha*), and mindfulness of death (*maraṇassati*)—which are shown as helpful preliminary meditation subjects (*kammaṭṭhāna*), and practicing them systematically, what does a person who sits for *ānāpānasati* do? By contemplating the breath, contemplating it subtly, or by establishing mindfulness (*sati*) on it, anchoring mindfulness therein, leaving no room for thoughts, and cutting off the arrows of Māra, one gradually quiets that in-breathing and out-breathing.

Along with this quieting, the understanding, the wisdom (*paññā*), becomes sharp. Like a diamond, like a diamond gem, like a beryl, that wisdom systematically grows through contemplating arising and passing away (*udayabbaya*), dissolution (*bhaṅga*), and so on, until at some point, comprehending the true nature of these formations (*saṅkhāra*)—this resistance in taking these in-breaths and out-breaths, this preparation, and the subtle saṃsāric bondage within it—one is able, at some moment, through the

penetration (*paṭivedha*) of the paths known as Sotāpanna (Stream-enterer), Sakadāgāmi (Once-returner), Anāgāmi (Non-returner), and Arahant, to be liberated from this bodily cage and attain that liberated mind.

If one has attained that liberated mind, even though from that point on they spend their remaining lifespan according to the momentum of past kamma gathered in the past, at the moment of death, when Māra pulls, no vibration occurs. When speaking of the final passing away (*pariNibbāna*) of the Buddha, some might misunderstand, thinking that the Buddha passed away because Māra came and invited him to do so. However, at the moment of the Buddha's final passing away, because his mind was entirely a liberated mind, he passed away peacefully, having attained that sublime peace. That peace is not present among ordinary worldly beings.

When an ordinary person dies, they lament amidst a multitude of torments and pains, take up thoughts regarding their relatives, die, and are born again in another place according to kamma. Thus, it continues continuously in this *saṃsāra*. This is what is described as the cycle of kamma (*kamma-vaṭṭa*), the cycle of defilements (*kilesa-vaṭṭa*), and the cycle of results (*vipāka-vaṭṭa*). Falling prey to those arrows, the flower-arrows shot by Māra, they accumulate various kinds of kamma. As a result of those kammas, subsequently, bodily cages arise—those bodily cages formed due to *avijjā* (ignorance) and *Taṇhā* (Craving). With every bodily cage that arises, Māra has great amusement. Māra pulls. Consequently, when pulled, they die lamenting amidst torment, fear, and terror.

That is what is called *Dukkha* (Suffering). Why is this word 'Māra' used? It is to represent the unrecognised *avijjā* (ignorance) and *Taṇhā* (Craving) inherent in worldly beings, making them understandable to the mind, so that one can carry out this journey to Nibbāna. That is why the Buddha has used the word 'Māra' on many occasions. There is indeed a class of beings called *Māra-devaputta* (Māra the deity). But here, what is mostly referred to as Māra is *kilesa-māra* (Māra of defilements), used in a way that is comprehensible to the mind. Because if it is not made into a clear Dhamma object (*dhamma-ārammaṇa*) in this manner, one will not make the necessary effort.

The Middle Path (*majjhimā paṭipadā*) is a middle way. Standing still does not work, and struggling does not work either. On a certain occasion, a deity came and asked the Buddha, "O painless one, how did you cross over the flood?" By 'flood' (*ogha*), what is meant is this saṃsāric flood of defilements. "How did you cross over this flood?" The Buddha declared: "By not halting and by not struggling, I crossed over the flood." If one halts—now, if a person caught in a

swift current suddenly stops, thinking there is nothing to be done, that is death. If one struggles frantically, that too is death. Instead, to escape from that flood, one systematically makes a wise effort. It is such a path that the Buddha pointed out as insight attention (*vipassanā-manasikāra*).

Therefore, on this valuable Poya day, you, meritorious friends, have listened to an analysis and exposition based on a word of Dhamma spoken by the Buddha, which helps to end this suffering of *saṃsāra*. Each of you must contemplate this. Do not stop merely at 'listening to Dhamma' as an ordinary custom; you must put it into practice in your daily life as much as possible, without delay. The Buddha declared these teachings in a way that they can be realized in daily life. It is mentioned in the Dhamma stories that not only the monks, but also lay devotees, both men and women, during the time of the Buddha and thereafter, leaned toward this path of Dhamma, systematically practiced meditation, and realized these truths, sometimes even before the monks.

Therefore, making an effort, we hope that you, meritorious friends, will use these Dhamma points discussed today, not merely to store them up as a heap of intellectual knowledge, but as an aid to sharpen your own diamond gem through insight, to develop your insight wisdom (*vipassanā-paññā*), and that you will extract the essence from this by reflecting on its practical value.

Thus, on a day like today, even though it was for a short time, you, meritorious friends, listened to the Dhamma. Within that lies faith (*saddhā*), the energy (*vīriya*) that followed that faith, the mindfulness (*sati*) brought forth through that energy, the concentration (*samādhi*) established through that mindfulness, and if any understanding arose through that concentration, the wisdom (*paññā*)—meaning, you were able to gain some sense of these valuable spiritual faculties (*indriya*) and powers (*bala*), which are parts of this Dhamma that can be directly realized by oneself. Today, therefore, you, meritorious friends, must rejoice, knowing that it is through the effort exerted in this manner that we will someday be able to escape from this fearful *saṃsāra*, from all of these—*Jāti* (Birth), *jarā* (decay/aging), disease, *maraṇa* (death), grief, and torment—and realize the great, supreme deathless Nibbāna. You must firmly resolve: "May you, meritorious friends, also have the strength and power to attain that peace in this very life without delay!"

Likewise, may the Sasana-protecting assembly of Devas and Brahmas, including the Deva and Brahma kings who, though unseen to us, constantly assist in these Sasana activities, rejoice in this merit of preaching and listening to the Dhamma! Having rejoiced, and providing protection to the Sasana and to us, may they realize the great, supreme Nibbāna through whichever Bodhi (enlightenment)

they aspire for! Similarly, from the Avīci hell up to the Akaniṭṭha heaven, may all those who desire merit and Nibbāna, including our deceased relatives, rejoice in this merit of listening to the Dhamma, escape from this fearful *saṃsāra*, and be comforted by the great, supreme Nibbāna! Making this aspiration, recite these verses and share the merits.

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”